



Where eagles dare

Fighting an alien enemy in a war-torn nation in Africa is part of a peacekeeping mission that India's elite pilots do not fly away from

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

When forty-year-old Wing Commander Ashutosh Lal straps himself into the bullet-proof bubble cockpit of an Mi-35 in Goma, Congo, his helmet-mounted sights—a pair of goggles weighing nearly 2 kg—swivel down over his eyes, making him look more cyborg than human. It seems appropriate for the machine he flies. The Indian Air Force's (IAF) heavily-armoured Mi-35 attack helicopter, bristling with cannons and rockets, is more of a flying tank than chopper. Lal is part of the Indian Aviation Contingent-2 (IAC-2), consisting of eight machines—including four transport helicopters—that is part of the UN peacekeeping force in the civil war-torn Democratic Republic of Congo. With over 8,00,000 casualties in the past decade, before ending in 2003, it's the worst conflict since the Second World War.

When Lal, born and raised in Lucknow, takes off in a furious argument of rotor-blades, he muses over the paradox of using force to enforce peace. As the gunship sweeps over the countryside, he can see the thick vegetation carpeting the mountains over 14,000 ft, not unusual for the equatorial country. The lava bubbling out of the still-active Mount Nyiragongo is an ominous portent of a sleeping monster which spewed lava across the runway the last time it awoke five years ago. It also mirrors the simmering discontent and the uneasy peace enforced by the UN troops. In this eastern Congolese town of Goma, the danger to UN troops comes from the marauding militia of Laurent Nkunda, one of the packs of rebel militias vying for control of the resource-cursed nation. In November last year, the warlord sent in hundreds of troops to attack the town Goma, where the UN forces are based. Lal and the mean machines of IAC-2 flew 22 missions in 48 hours through day and night, beating them back with rockets and cannon fire, eventually targeting their base camp to rout the offensive. It helps that these Soviet-built sledgehammers were recently upgraded with Israeli electronics, including a

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large football-sized pod packed with infra-red sensors, to fly like bats through the night. These were the first night attack missions in UN history and drew plaudits from the organisation. For Lal, who, as a three-year-old drew an aircraft when asked for his ambition, it was a vindication. "Because we represent the country, our military conduct and professionalism has to be at the forefront," says the pilot.

The Mi-35's 23 mm chin cannon is straight out of a sci-fi flick. It can swivel and fire wherever Lal looks. The rockets can be fired at the flick of a switch but Lal, a test pilot and instructor with 5,700 flying hours, has to go through a complicated system of procedures to ensure no harm comes to civilians or to their own UN blue helmets—a division of Indian, Pakistani and Bangladeshi troops of UN peacekeepers. This task is made difficult by the ease with which the